Great Game as Britain. It too looked to extend its influence into those countries on its frontiers in order to secure its territories; it too looked to its imperial rival with fear lest that rival gained influence at its expense in Asia; and it too sent numerous agents, spies and adventurers into the arena of the Great Game in order to counter British moves. Indeed, it was the Russian foreign minister, Count Nesselrode, who coined the alternative term for the Great Game, the 'Tournament of Shadows'.[79] Whether Russia was as committed to, or as obsessed with, the Great Game as Britain is perhaps an issue up for debate. However, what is certain is that Britain was not simply playing with its own shadow, nor was Russia simply a passive participant in the process. That Russia was a very real nemesis to Britain in the period prior to the First World War is also important when it comes to understanding the mental maps which might have influenced decision-makers in the post-war years.

Curzon

One figure who epitomised the typical British Great Game player and Russophobe was George Nathaniel Curzon. A notoriously divisive figure, contemporary opinion of Curzon was mixed. To some, such as Lord Beaverbrook, Curzon was 'inconsistent, unreliable, untruthful and treacherous'.[80] A.J.P. Taylor once described him as 'one of nature's rats',[81] while Lloyd George famously revelled in mocking his Cabinet colleague for his aristocratic background. Montagu's feelings on Curzon were complex:

[He] amuses me, interests me, irritates me. Extraordinarily easy to deal with in the upshot, but, oh! what a process! Do you know that one of my daily duties is to write a letter to Curzon? Every day he wants some information about some Indian matter; every day he is critical about something or other; and he seems to find time to read the million and one papers which a War Cabinet Minister has to read, to write in his own handwriting any number of letters to his colleagues, and it will amuse you that on a day when I know that he had two meetings of the War Cabinet and a meeting of the Eastern